Week 8 Case: Three Polls, Three Answers

You are: a campaign manager for a competitive state Senate race.

Today: September 2026. The general election is eight weeks away. You need to decide how to allocate your final $2 million across TV ads, digital ads, and field operations. The allocation depends heavily on where the race stands. If you're ahead, you play defense; if you're behind, you go on offense.

The polls

Three polls of your race have been released in the past two weeks. They disagree:

Poll	Method	Sample size	Result
Landmark Research (phone)	Live-caller phone interviews	~1,000 likely voters	**Rep +4**
Progressive Data Institute (online)	Online panel survey	~1,000 likely voters	**Dem +8**
State University Poll (mixed)	Phone + online, post-stratified	~1,200 registered voters	**Dem +1**

Your finance director says: "The university poll says we're up 1. Let's play it safe and go heavy on TV." Your field director says: "Landmark has us down 4. We need to go all-in on voter contact." Your digital consultant says: "The online poll shows we're crushing it. Let's bank the money."

They can't all be right.

What you know about polling

- **Phone polls** tend to reach older, more engaged voters. Younger voters often don't pick up calls from unknown numbers.
- **Online polls** tend to reach younger, more internet-savvy respondents. Older voters are underrepresented unless the pollster actively recruits them.
- **Post-stratification** means the pollster adjusts the sample after the fact to match the known population on demographics like age, race, education, and party registration. The idea: if your sample has too many old people, give each young person more weight.
- In 2020, most polls underestimated Republican support, by 3.9 points on the national

margin. The AAPOR task force ruled out the obvious explanations (late-deciding voters, education weighting, the demographic mix, shy Trump voters, differential turnout). It concluded that **nonresponse bias** contributed but could not show it was the main cause: that the people who chose to take the survey were systematically different from the people who didn't, in ways demographics alone couldn't fix. Nobody has conclusively explained 2020.

The decision

Which poll do you trust? How do you allocate the $2 million?

Things to think about:

1. The phone poll and the online poll disagree by 12 points. They surveyed different people. What kind of voter answers a phone poll? What kind signs up for an online panel?
2. If the phone poll oversamples old voters and old voters lean Republican, what happens to the topline when you reweight the sample to match the population's age distribution?
3. The university poll used post-stratification. Does that solve the problem? What if the people who respond to surveys are different from non-respondents *within* each demographic group (politically engaged 25-year-olds respond, disengaged 25-year-olds don't)?
4. After 2016 and 2020, should you just add a few points to the Republican in every poll? Why might that be a bad idea?